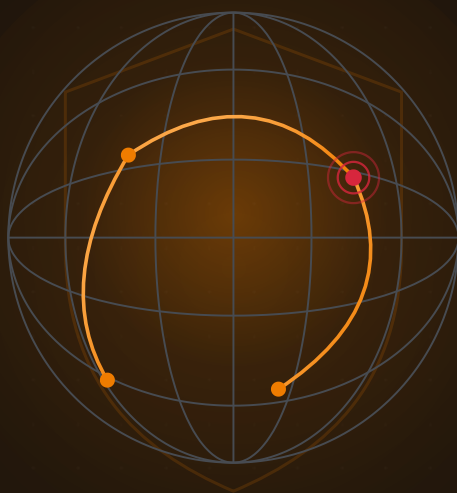




THREAT PULSE

WEEKLY CYBER THREAT BRIEFING

WEEK IN REVIEW · 28 SEPTEMBER – 4 OCTOBER 2026

A critical, already-exploited flaw in Fortinet's FortiMail email gateway —
plus urgent fixes for Apple devices, Cisco networks and Kiteworks.

Welcome to **Threat Pulse**, your plain-English weekly round-up of the cyber threats making waves around the world — and what they mean for your business. This week's standout story is a critical flaw in **Fortinet's FortiMail** email security gateway that attackers are **already exploiting** — before any patch was ready. We also cover urgent emergency fixes for **Apple devices**, **Cisco** network managers and **Kiteworks**. No jargon, just what happened and the practical steps worth taking.

AT A GLANCE THIS WEEK

 **9.8** /10

Severity of this week's FortiMail flaw (critical)

 **Zero-day**

Exploited before any patch existed

 **4 Oct**

CISA's fix-by date for US federal agencies

THIS WEEK'S HEADLINE THREAT

FORTINET FORTIMAIL · CVE-2026-104286

Critical flaw in Fortinet's FortiMail email gateway — and attackers are already using it

9.8
/10 CVSS

CRITICAL

Exploitation: **active — exploited in the wild (zero-day)**

WHAT'S HAPPENING

On **1 October 2026** Fortinet warned of a critical flaw (**CVE-2026-104286**, rated **9.8 out of 10**) in **FortiMail**, its email security gateway. The flaw lets an attacker who has not logged in send specially crafted web requests that plant their own files on the device — enough to gain a foothold and take it over. Fortinet confirmed it is **already being exploited** in real attacks, and at the time of writing a full patch is still on the way, with interim protections available in the meantime. The US cyber agency **CISA** added it to its official “must-fix” list the same day.

WHO'S AFFECTED

Any organisation running a **FortiMail appliance** (software versions 7.2, 7.4, 7.6 and 8.0), and especially those whose FortiMail management page can be **reached from the internet**. FortiMail sits in front of company email to filter spam and malware, so it is common in businesses that run their own mail security rather than relying purely on cloud email.

WHY IT MATTERS TO YOU

An email gateway sees **every message coming in and going out**. If attackers control it, they can read mail, harvest passwords, and use it as a launch pad deeper into the network — all before a single phishing email ever reaches a person. Because it is being exploited right now and the full fix is still landing, the window to act is tight.

Good news: if your email runs on a cloud service such as Microsoft 365 or Google Workspace, you do not run a FortiMail appliance and this particular flaw does not affect you. For everyone else, Fortinet has published interim steps that close the hole until the patch arrives — and simply making sure the device's admin page is not exposed to the internet removes the main way in.

What to do about the headline threat

-  Ask your IT team or provider one question this week: **do we run a FortiMail email gateway** — and if so, have we applied Fortinet's interim protections (turn off the IBE feature, and block the management page from the internet) and lined up the patch? If your email is cloud-based (Microsoft 365 or Google Workspace), just confirm that, and you are clear of this one.

OTHER THREATS WORTH KNOWING ABOUT



HIGH

Apple rushes out an emergency fix for iPhones, iPads and Macs

On **28 September** Apple released emergency updates for a flaw (**CVE-2026-86950**) that was already being used in what it called an **extremely sophisticated attack** on specific, targeted people. Opening a booby-trapped file could let an attacker run their own code on the device. It is fixed in **iOS and iPadOS 26.7.1**, **macOS Tahoe 26.7.1** and **macOS Sequoia 15.8.1**; CISA added it to its must-fix list on 29 September.

Takeaway: update every iPhone, iPad and Mac now (**Settings > General > Software Update**) and switch on automatic updates.



HIGH

A critical flaw lets attackers walk straight into Cisco network managers

Cisco confirmed attackers are exploiting a critical flaw (**CVE-2026-76504**, rated **9.8 out of 10**) in **Catalyst SD-WAN Manager** — the console many larger organisations use to run their networks. A single crafted web request lets an attacker who has not logged in gain **full administrator access**. Cisco has released fixes, and CISA set a fix-by date of **3 October**.

Takeaway: if your organisation uses Cisco Catalyst SD-WAN Manager, your IT team should apply Cisco's update straight away.



MEDIUM

A second email-gateway flaw — patch it before attackers notice

Kiteworks patched a **maximum-severity flaw** (**CVE-2026-54154**) in its Email Protection Gateway that could let an attacker who has not logged in run commands and take full control of the device. **No attacks have been seen yet** — a friendly researcher found it first — so updating now gets you ahead of it.

Takeaway: if you run Kiteworks, update to the latest fixed version right away, while there is still a head start.

★ Your 3-minute checklist this week

- ✓ Ask whether you run a **FortiMail email gateway**; if so, apply Fortinet's interim steps and plan the patch.
- ✓ Update all **Apple devices** — iPhones, iPads and Macs — and turn on automatic updates.
- ✓ Check whether any **Cisco Catalyst SD-WAN Manager** or **Kiteworks** gateway needs its vendor's latest fix.
- ✓ Make sure no device's **admin or management page** is reachable from the public internet.
- ✓ Confirm your **offline backup** actually restores — don't just assume it does.

Threat Pulse is provided by DPG-Cyber for general awareness only and does not constitute specific security or legal advice. Threat details are drawn from reputable public reporting as at 5 October 2026 and may evolve as investigations continue. For guidance tailored to your environment, please contact your DPG-Cyber account team.

BEHIND THE HEADLINES

Why a **watchful eye** changes the outcome

Every threat in this issue had one thing in common: the damage happened in the **quiet gap between the break-in and the moment someone noticed**. Tools alone rarely stop an attack — what limits the harm is continuous monitoring that correlates the signals, spots the intrusion early, and responds before a foothold becomes a crisis.

247 days

Average time for organisations to identify *and* contain a breach

SOURCE: IBM COST OF A DATA BREACH 2026

\$4.99M

Global average total cost of a single data breach

SOURCE: IBM COST OF A DATA BREACH 2026

THE WINDOW THAT MATTERS

Intrusion
the way in

Foothold
quietly settling in

Lateral movement
spreading across systems

Impact
data theft / ransomware

↑ The sooner an attack is spotted, the smaller the damage. Closing this window — detecting and responding on the left, long before impact on the right — is the entire job of a Security Operations Centre.

WHAT CONTINUOUS MONITORING QUIETLY DOES



Sees across everything

A SIEM gathers and correlates activity from across your systems, so unusual behaviour stands out instead of hiding in the noise.



Watches around the clock

Attacks don't keep office hours. A SOC means real people monitoring day, night and weekends — not just 9 to 5.



Knows the latest tactics

Fresh threat intelligence — like the email-gateway and network-appliance attacks in this issue — feeds detection so new tricks are recognised fast.



Acts, not just alerts

Alerts are triaged and investigated by analysts who step in early, turning a would-be incident into a non-event.

CLIENT ACTION OF THE WEEK

THIS WEEK'S FIX

Update your Apple devices today

Apple's emergency fix closes a flaw that was **already used in targeted attacks**. Update every iPhone, iPad and Mac (Settings > General > Software Update) and turn on **automatic updates** so the next fix installs itself.

GOOD HABIT

Keep tested, offline backups

A backup only counts if it works when you need it. Keep at least one copy **offline or off-site**, beyond the reach of ransomware, and actually **test a restore** from time to time — a backup you have never tested is a guess, not a safety net.

This is the quiet, everyday work behind **DPG-Cyber's SIEM & SOC services** — the same monitoring and response that turns headlines like these into non-events for the businesses we look after. If you're ever curious how it would map to your own environment, we're always happy to talk it through, no pressure — just drop us a line at hello@dpg-cyber.com.